

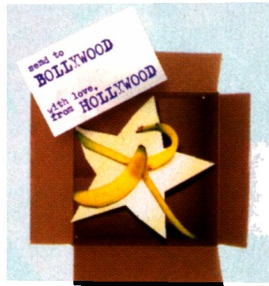
ROUGH CUT KAVEREE BAMZAI

Republic of the Rejected



Anyone find anything odd in Bollywood celebrating its recent "Hollywood" coups? Happy because it got Snoop Dogg, a man well known for running into trouble for possession of marijuana and guns, and for having been a professional pimp for two years, to sing a song for *Singh is King*? Over the moon that Kareena Kapoor was made an offer to act in a film directed by Daniel Silverman who, according to her over-heated publicity machine, directed *The Devil Wears Prada* and *The Perfect Stranger* (no matter that the credits list him in the miscellaneous crew as the film recorder)? Or that Sylvester Stallone acted for "three whole days" in the forthcoming *Kambakht Ishq* (remember Sly? He was big, very big, but in the 1980s)? We've all heard of dumping of First World goods and effluents in Third World economies. This is toxic dumping of another kind. Anyone in downslide of their careers in the West, hey, welcome to India. So if Manoj Night Shyamalan has just fought with Disney and rapidly morphed from golden boy to prime nutter, hey, come to UTV. Shekhar Kapur is out of favour in Hollywood—having managed to turn *Golden Age* into a giant turkey—hey, again, come home. Michael Douglas wants to revive an action franchise that began in 1984 (another one of those guys who was big in the '80s), so where do you think he heads? Yes, you got it. And if someone called Willard Carroll can't get a film made in America, please crash at Salman Khan's pad and make *Marigold*, the most famous Hollywood film you never heard of.

Fortunately, no one uses that most-hated term any more, crossover. Considering that Indians have actually taken over so many parts of the world—from Kensington Gardens to Silicon Valley—it does seem an all-too-modest ambition for Bollywood. But this reverse trend of converting Bollywood into a republic of the rejected does make one cross one's fingers for the deal Reliance is close to striking with DreamWorks. Steven Spielberg shouldn't go from being the most saleable director of all time to flop factory, though it has to be said there is a lot of sniping out there about how he has become unaffordable for Americans. The Anil Ambani conglomerate has also struck deals with several major actors and directors (among them George Clooney and Chris Columbus), but none of these is likely to happen overnight. In the meantime, we have to live with walk-on parts on the world stage, sometimes a role in the *Pink Panther* franchise, sometimes a visit from Will Smith. And yes, many big deals for people who were once big deals.



SAURABH SINGH



UNWANTED: Khanduri

General Troubles

DEHRADUN The dissent between the rank and file of the BJP and Uttarakhand Chief Minister Major-General (retd) Bhuwan Chand Khanduri has finally come to a head. Nearly 26 of the 36 MLAs, including a few ministers, have asked BJP President Rajnath Singh to sack Khanduri immediately. The chief minister, they claim, is inaccessible, and is functioning through senior IAS officer Prabhat Sarangi, whose high-handedness is causing resentment.

When he was appointed chief minister in 2007,

there were apprehensions that the former major-general would run the state like an army officer. Prior to the polls, Rajnath Singh and Bhagat Singh Koshiyari campaigned extensively in the tiny hill state. But after the BJP's victory, Koshiyari was sidelined and Khanduri was appointed chief minister. So far, Rajnath has been diplomatically saving Khanduri's chief ministership, but will he be able to save the BJP's prospects in the coming panchayat and Lok Sabha polls is the question that is haunting the party. **by Subhash Mishra**

Dwindling Greenery

BANGALORE The city's reputation of being India's garden city may be crushed. A new study indicates that the city's green cover is down by 20 per cent and is declining fast. The decline is at an average of 30 sq km annually in the past six years. On the other hand, built-up area has increased by 61.6 per cent, from 186.42

sq km to 301.27 sq km. The area of vegetation in and around the city has gone down from 859.24 sq km to 684.85 sq km.

It is time for more parks, trees and more green cover so that the city, whose reputation has already taken a beating, does not take any further battering.

by Stephen David